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lecturer in Economics at The Open University. "At the same time, consumer borrowing has also risen in cost, dousing any hope of a post-pandemic bounceback of growth-promoting investment. The present high rate of inflation would also, in the past, have eased the government's financial pressures by eroding the costs of public and private debt. But that shield has worn thin. Payments on 25 per cent of the government's debt are now aligned with the inflation rate, and lenders are rapidly passing on the rise in borrowing costs to mortgage and credit card borrowers." What Sunak does for the economy in the next month will make or break his premiership, if not the UK.

While there is euphoria in India over his appointment, experts believe that he may turn out to be more loyal than the King and be tougher on India. His reappointment of Suella Braverman as home minister signals a rough road ahead for the negotiations on a free trade agreement with India that was to conclude on Diwali. When Truss was prime minister, Braverman as her home secretary had said she had "concerns" about the trade deal because it would increase migration to the UK, and Indians represented the largest group of visa overstayers. India has been calling for the free movement of people to accompany the free movement of goods, and her comments provoked angry reactions from New Delhi. In April, both countries targeted a doubling of bilateral trade by 2030, up from its current value of $30 billion. India wants to increase exports of leather, textiles, jewellery and food products to Britain, while the UK is keen to sell more whisky to India, by reducing the import duty of 150 per cent. But relaxation of visa rules has been one of India's main demands, and reinstalling Braverman could make this trade deal a casualty.

NOT A PRAGMATIC CENTRIST, SUNAK LIKE THATCHER IS A VOTARY OF FISCAL DISCIPLINE. HE'LL HAVE TO TAKE TOUGH DECISIONS, INCLUDING SPENDING CUTS, IF HE WANTS TO AVOID IMPOSING TAXES

The other challenge for Rishi is to move beyond his privileged upper-class background and address the cost-of-living crisis in the country. Sunak's immense wealth works against him, earning him the derisive sobriquet of 'Rishi Rich'. He, his wife and two daughters, Krishna and Anoushka, live mostly at their five-bedroom house in a Kensington cul-de-sac in west London, worth around £7 million. On weekends, the family retreats to their Grade II-listed Georgian manor house in the village of Kirby Sigston in his Richmond constituency in North Yorkshire. The house, bought in 2015, is now worth more than £2 million. Later, he gave the house a face-lift with a £400,000 indoor swimming pool, gym, yoga studio, hot tub and tennis court. Rising energy costs mean it will cost more than £14,000 a year to heat the 12 metre by 5 metre pool, almost six times the average family's energy bill.

His clumsy flaunting of wealth comes at a time when millions of Britons are thinking how they are going to survive as two-thirds are facing fuel poverty and hundreds of excess deaths are expected during the winter. His £450 Prada loafers and £180 smart coffee mug have attracted criticism and snarky social media memes. The Sunaks own a flat on Old Brompton Road in west London for visiting family, and also a Santa Monica beach penthouse valued at £5.5 million. In a podcast with the *Telegraph*, Sunak said he is not dodging that question. "I actually quite welcome it, to be honest. It's the opposite of annoying. Very few people bring it up with me. While I was chancellor, I did town hall meetings very regularly with members of the public ... virtually nobody asked me about it. Values are what are important, what I'm wearing is irrelevant to all of that."

In 1947, a half-naked fakir, as Winston Churchill disparagingly called Mahatma Gandhi once, brought the mighty British Empire down to its knees and forced it to grant India independence. In a perfect irony, 75 years later, a man of Indian descent dressed in designer suits with creases so sharp that they can cut you, is seeking to liberate Britain from economic gloom. The Maha Rishi is all set to turn 10, Downing Street into his ashram from where he will rule the island of rainy clouds and cupcakes, with wide-ranging consequences for people at home and abroad. ■